Understanding the ‘find‘ Command: A Beginner’s Guide to Mastery

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July 03, 2025

1 Introduction

The ‘find‘ command is a powerful tool in Linux and Unix-like systems used to search for files and directories based on various criteria such as name, type, size, permissions, and more. In Capture The Flag (CTF) challenges, it’s invaluable for locating hidden flags, configuration files, or exploitable binaries. This document will guide you from the basics to advanced usage, ensuring you can write your own ‘find‘ commands confidently.

2 Basic Concepts

- **Purpose**: ‘find‘ searches the filesystem recursively from a specified starting point. - **Syntax**: ‘find [starting-point] [expression]‘ - ‘[starting-point]‘: Where to start (e.g., ‘/‘ for the root directory). - ‘[expression]‘: Conditions and actions (e.g., ‘-name‘, ‘-type‘, ‘-exec‘). - **Default Behavior**: Without options, it lists all files and dirs from the start point.

3 Getting Started: Basic Usage

3.1 Finding Files by Name

- To find a file by its name, use the ‘-name‘ option. - Example: Find a file named ‘flag.txt‘ in ‘/home‘:

```
    find /home -name "flag.txt"
```

- **Note**: The name is case-sensitive unless you use ‘-iname‘ for case-insensitive search.

3.2 Specifying File Type

- Use ‘-type‘ to filter by file type: - ‘f‘: Regular file - ‘d‘: Directory - ‘l‘: Symbolic link - Example: Find only regular files named ‘secret‘:

```
    find / -type f -name "secret"
```

4 Intermediate Techniques

4.1 Combining Conditions

- Use ‘-o‘ (OR) and ‘-a‘ (AND) to combine searches. - Example: Find files named ‘flag.txt‘ or ‘key.txt‘:

```
    find / -type f \( -name "flag.txt" -o -name "key.txt" \)
```

- **Parentheses**: Group conditions with “*and*“ (escaped for shell).

4.2 Ignoring Permission Errors

- Redirect errors to ‘/dev/null‘ to keep output clean:

```
 find / -type f -name "config" 2>/dev/null
```

4.3 Executing Commands on Found Files

- Use ‘-exec‘ to run a command on each match: - Example: List details of found files:

```
    find / -type f -name "log*" -exec ls -l {} \;
```

- “: Placeholder for the file path. - ‘ ‘: Terminates the ‘-exec‘ clause.

5 Advanced Usage

5.1 Filtering by Permissions and Ownership

- **Permissions**: Use ‘-perm‘ to match mode (e.g., ‘755‘ for ‘rwxr-xr-x‘). - Example: Find executable files by all:

```
    find / -type f -perm 755
```

- **Ownership**: Use ‘-user‘ (username) or ‘-uid‘ (numeric ID), ‘-group‘ (group name) or ‘-gid‘ (numeric GID). - Example: Find files owned by group ‘admin‘:

```
    find / -type f -group admin
```

5.2 Size and Time Filters

- **Size**: Use ‘-size‘ (e.g., ‘+10M‘ for over 10MB, ‘10k‘ for 10KB). - Example: Find files larger than 1MB:

```
    find / -type f -size +1M
```

- **Time**: Use ‘-mtime‘ (modification time in days), ‘-atime‘ (access time), ‘-ctime‘ (change time). - Example: Find files modified in the last day:

```
    find / -type f -mtime -1
```

5.3 Complex Examples

- Find and delete old logs:

```
find /var/log -type f -name "*.log" -mtime +30 -exec rm {} \;
```

- Find and hash files:

```
find / -type f -name "*.txt" -exec sha1sum {} \; > hashes.txt
```

6 Practical CTF Application

In your current CTF, you used:

```
find / -type f \( -name 8V2L -o -name bny0 -o -name c4ZX -o -name
    D8B3 -o -name FH11 -o -name oiM0 -o -name PFbD -o -name rmfX -o -
    name SRSq -o -name uqyw -o -name v2Vb -o -name X1Uy \) -exec ls -
    ilrt {} \; 2>>/dev/null
```

- **Breakdown**: - ‘/‘: Starts at root. - ‘-type f‘: Limits to files. - ‘‘...‘‘: Groups OR conditions for multiple names. - ‘-o‘: Logical OR between names. - ‘-exec ls -ilrt ‘: Runs ‘ls -ilrt‘ (inode, long, reverse time sort) on each match. - ‘2»/dev/null‘: Suppresses errors. - **Customization**: Add ‘-exec cat ‘ to view contents or ‘-exec wc -l ‘ for line counts.

7 Writing Your Own ‘find‘ Command

To craft a command yourself: 1. **Choose Start Point**: Where to search (e.g., ‘/‘, ‘/home‘). 2. **Set Conditions**: Use ‘-name‘, ‘-type‘, ‘-perm‘, etc. 3. **Combine Logic**: Use ‘$‘and‘-o‘or‘-a‘.4.**AddAction** : Use‘-exec‘withacommand(e.g.,‘ls‘,‘cat‘).5.**HandleErrors** : Add‘2 > /dev/null‘$.

Example Exercise Find all executable files owned by user ‘ctfuser‘ modified in the last 7 days:

```
find / -type f -perm /u+x -user ctfuser -mtime -7 -exec ls -l {} \;
    2>/dev/null
```

8 Conclusion

With these steps, you can now build ‘find‘ commands tailored to any CTF scenario. Practice by searching for files with specific names, types, or properties, and use ‘-exec‘ to analyze them. Experiment on your target (e.g., ‘10.10.45.184‘) to solidify your skills!